

“Acquisition is the easy part; execution is what creates value”

Ranjan Pai, Chairman, Manipal Education and Medical Group, on his professional journey, learning from failures, and what makes the group click

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Manipal Health Enterprises debuted on stock exchanges on August 5 and listed at a 10.5% premium after raising over ₹9,275 crore in India's second-largest IPO of 2026. The issue was subscribed five times, valuing the hospital chain around 85 times FY26 earnings, one of the highest multiples in the sector. But the listing is only the latest milestone in a journey that has transformed it into one of India's largest private healthcare networks.

In his first interview since the listing, Dr. Ranjan Pai, Chairman of the Manipal Education and Medical Group (MEMD), speaks to BT about the company's next phase of growth, the rationale behind the valuation, capital allocation plans

and the role of private equity in building a scalable healthcare business. He also reflects on his journey from medicine to institution building, lessons from failed acquisition bids, why attracting talent is central to Manipal's strategy, and the future of India's healthcare sector. Edited excerpts:

Q: You trained as a doctor but went on to build one of India's largest healthcare groups. How did that journey begin?

A: After completing my medical degree, I went to the US to study hospital administration. I got an opportunity to join the group in Malaysia. A medical school was being set up there, and my father asked me if I would like to go and set it up. Setting up a college gave me full hands-on experience of doing everything away from India and Manipal.

“MEMG was set up in 2000 as the holding company to assemble talent. We followed a model like the Tatas, bringing talent together and looking at new businesses to build”
